ASSETS '26 · ACM TACCESS 18(3), 2025

WHO MAKES MUSIC SOFTWARE ACCESSIBLE?

The Qualities of Convivial Tools and Their Relevance to Music Software Accessibility

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QUEEN'S UNIVERSITY BELFAST

SARC: CENTRE FOR INTERDISCIPLINARY RESEARCH IN SOUND AND MUSIC

DESIGNERS CAN'T SEE THE FUTURE



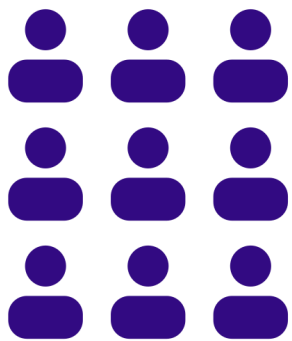
- Usability tests: a handful of people, for about an hour
- But tools live in a busy world of people, places and things

> "It isn't only that we use tools; we think with them."
> — Alva Noë

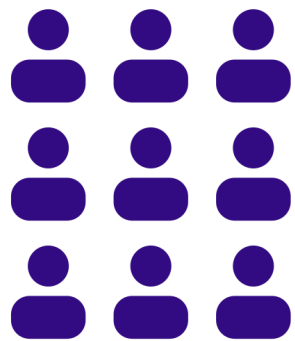
We can't fully anticipate how a tool will be used until it's in use.

20 SOUND CREATIVES

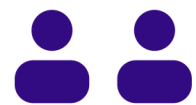
9 advanced



9 intermediate



2 beginner



All blind or visually impaired · 9 countries · 2-hour sessions

THREE GAPS

BRIDGED BY COMMUNITY



> "There is a lot of goodwill without the backup."
>
> — Peter Bosher

COMMUNITIES BUILD THE BRIDGES

1. **Mailing lists and WhatsApp groups** for each DAW (digital audio workstation)
2. **OSARA**: screen-reader access for Reaper, built by the community
3. **Thousands of preset files**, made by hand

> "The WhatsApp groups are very voice message focused."
> — Rory McDonald

A DAW is often accessible only with the community's knowledge.

Sighted users get a working product at the point of purchase.

ILLICH: TOOLS FOR CONVIVIALITY

A convivial tool is:

1. Easy to learn by using it
2. Used when and where **you** choose
3. Adaptable to **you**

...and community is at its heart.



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THREE DESIGN GUIDELINES

GUIDELINE 1

Build accessible ecosystems

Tutorials and manuals without visual cues

GUIDELINE 2

Embrace interdependent access

Credit community work, and point people to it

GUIDELINE 3

Design for designers

Open extension points: the DAW is ajar

Make tools malleable, and support the communities who change them.

"Nothing about us without us", where **us** is a community.

THANK YOU!

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Feedback, 2 minutes
noiseguaranteed.org/assets26/feedback

Slides and script
noiseguaranteed.org/assets26

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